The Bihar incidents, and others less violent, alert us to that crisis by singling out a new phenomenon: a collective obsession for a government job. A paradox, at first sight. In the fourth decade of post-liberalisation India, after two generations of talk about shrinking governments and the explosion of the 'new economy', you would have expected the opposite? Well, that story has not exactly been going to script.

The Hunger

Five years ago, India's unemployment rate stood at a 45-year-high of 6.1 per cent, according to the NSSO's periodic labour force survey. What the 2017-18 data revealed to us is that we were back to the dire situation of the early seventies, the exact time when student and union unrest changed India's politics forever and tropes like the Angry Young Man got permanently embedded in our culture. It is simplistic to compare across periods with vastly different population sizes, but the conclusion is still startling: over a quarter century of reforms had paradoxically given India the same job scenario that a quarter century of socialism had, post-Independence.

We all know the potted history from there on. The economy began to decline starting from the global downturn of 2008. Over the past decade, the country faced demonetisation, GST and, finally Covid, which forced a shell-shocked private sector to cut millions of jobs. By the government's own admission, 2.3 million people lost jobs across industries—manufacturing, construction, trade, transport, education, health, hospitality, IT/ BPOs and financial services during the 2020 lockdown. According to the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE), unemployment touched a high of 24 per cent in May 2020, at the peak of the pandemic. It even claims there was a 46 per cent decline—from 51 million in 2016-17 to 27.3 million in 2020-21—in jobs in manufacturing, which accounts for nearly 17 per cent of India's economy. A massive setback to the Centre's original 2022 target of increasing manufacturing employment to 100 million.

The unemployment rate has since eased, hovering just above the 7 per cent range this quarter—comparable to the pre-Covid period—but the National Statistical Office released data this week that underlines the essential uncertainty of the phase we are in: in April-June '21, urban unemployment had spiked to 12.6 per



BANDEEP SINGH

UTTAR PRADESH: Rakesh Pal, 28, *B.Sc. (Chemistry)*

Job applied for: Non-technical categories in railways
Total vacancies: 35,281; Total applications: 12.5 mn

Rakesh left his home at Jaunpur in Uttar Pradesh in 2015, a year after completing his graduation in chemistry from Veer Bahadur Singh Purvanchal University. He hoped the exposure in national capital Delhi would help him get a secure government job that would do justice to his degree in chemistry. Seven years later, he is yet to land his dream job. In 2019, he was driven by desperation to apply for the non-technical popular categories of jobs in Indian railways such as guards, clerks and time-keepers. When results were announced earlier this year, he learnt he had been placed in a level-5 job, based on his performance in what he assumed to be a screening test. "We thought the first test was a qualifying one, and that the score in the second test would determine the level of jobs that we would be selected for. That's why we protested. Even after waiting for three years, we did not get the job we wanted," says a dejected Rakesh. Meanwhile, he got enrolled at the Faculty of Law, Delhi University, and is preparing to become a lawyer.